

‘We need to develop a culture in which sport is seen as a way of life’

Raksha Khadse, Minister of State for Sports, stresses the need for stronger infrastructure, better governance, and grassroots development to **boost Indian sports.**

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The Indian government has laid out an ambitious plan to host the 2030 Commonwealth Games and the 2036 Olympics. However, the country's performance at

the 2024 Paris Olympics saw a dip from its Tokyo high, as Indian athletes returned with six medals (one silver, five bronze), one less compared to its Tokyo tally (1 gold, two silver, four bronze).

Minister of State for Sports, Raksha Khadse, in an interview with Sportstar, said the government is focused on improving sports

infrastructure to help young athletes give their best. “We have to provide them with a healthy environment to compete and progress,” she said.

Age fraud has been a huge issue in Indian sports. The Draft National Code Against Age Fraud in Sports shifts the focus from medical testing to digital document verification, among other measures. How does this new approach improve upon the 2010 framework, and how effectively do you think it can tackle age fraud in Indian sports?

Our digital verification system, the NSRS (National Sports Repository System), reduces reliance on invasive tests by ensuring authenticity through robust, traceable records. It streamlines processes and enhances transparency, as it works on a strong digital infrastructure and continuous audits. Records of all athletes will be documented. Going forward, their practice schedules and performances will be monitored daily. Nothing will be hidden. This transparency will help. From a young age, their progress will be monitored through this app, and that will help us tackle